प्रत्नकीर्तिमपावृणु

REPORT ON EXCAVATION AT PARABHADI (SUKHUAPADA) TEHSIL DARPANA, DISTRICT JAJPUR, ODISHA 2022-2023



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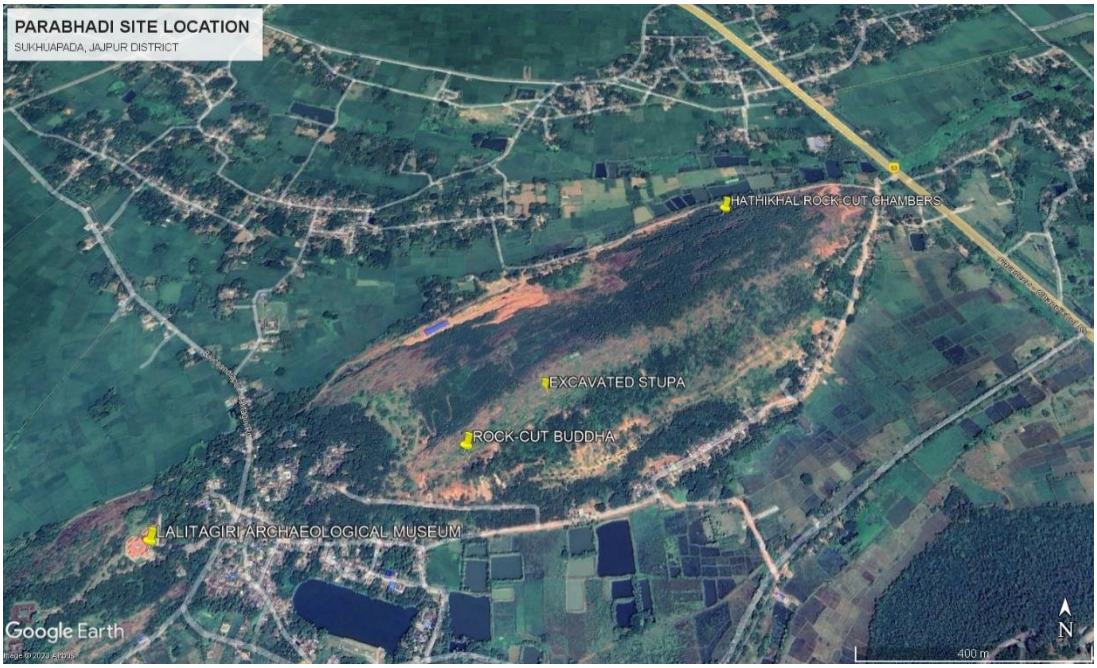
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Introduction

The Excavated site at the top of the Parabhadi hillock (Lat. 20° 35' 40" N, Long. 86° 15'39" E and MSL -137.487m) is in the Darpana Tehsil, Jajpur District of Odisha. The hillock is oriented Northeast – South west extending around 1.5km is a part of the Assia range, an offshoot of eastern ghat hill range. The site is located 5.5km from Balichandrapur, a nearby town on the national highway-53 running from Hajira in Gujarat and Paradeep port and about 80 kms north-east of Bhubaneswar, the state capital of Odisha.



Map showing the location of the site

Parabhadi hill (also called Sukhuapada hill) surrounded by Sukhuapada village in the south, Bandareswar in the north-east and Lalitagiri in the south-west, Kesharaipur village in the north. At present the heritage hillock lies in the Jajpur and Cuttack districts is significant for its rich archaeological vestiges in term of brick mounds, scattered stone structural remains, rock-cut caves and images. The local legend refers the Parabhadi hillock (para = pigeon, bhadi = storey/house) as the shelter of pigeon built by the king to train pigeon to carry message to different locality in that time.

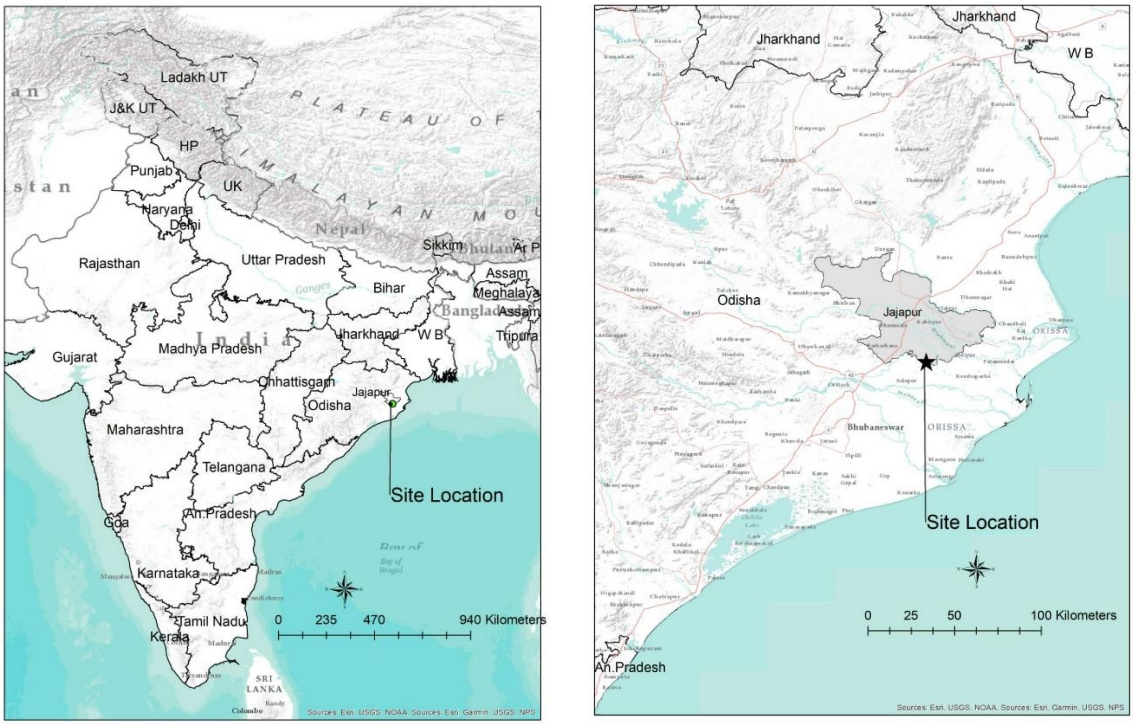
The close surroundings of the hills are formed by a vast stretch of low-lying fertile plain carried away by age long alluvium deposit of the Gobari *nullah (*stream*)*, a tributary of the Chitrotpala. The low-lying plain area around Lalitagiri is always susceptible to annual floods being in the midst of high rain fall zone. This natural phenomenon perhaps

provoked the villagers to settle on the higher areas, hence the present congested locality found concentrated at the foot hills of Nandapahada and the Parabhadi.

The Parabhadi hill is composed of lateritic soil and khondalite rock boulders at a north-south stretch of 1.5km in length and 0.5km east-west in width. The hillock is covered with modern Eucalyptus, Casuarina and Cashew plantation as well as Pipal, Banyan and Neem trees. The northern slope near mouza Kesharaipur contained seven minor rock-cut caves on its western face dedicated to Buddhist affinity. In early part of 20th century sculptural remains from the site shifted to Lalitagiri sculpture shed. Prior to this, few sculptures were removed by Rama Prasad Chanda, now housed in the Indian Museum, Kolkata. The hill was subjected to merciless and large-scale quarrying activities of soil and stone boulders for laying modem roads and construction of houses. The present excavation at the top of the hill exposed a large stone-built stupa which is visible from a longer distance i.e., from the national highway 53.

Archaeological Environment

The present archaeological site is surrounded by Lalitgiri, Udayagiri, Ratnagiri, Langudi, and Radhanagar heritage sites. Lalitagiri is the closest Buddhist site seems to be a part and parcel of Parabhadi in ancient time. The rock cut caves in the north-east portion of the Parabhadi hillock are locally named as Hathikhal.



Map showing the location of the site

Hathikhal is a series of 7 rock-cut chambers hewn out in the vertical rock surface of Parabhadi facing north-west. These rock-cut chambers are scooped out in horse-shoe shape in different sizes adjacent to each other. Besides this, there was a gallery of life-size images of Bodhisattvas and weathered roof of a structure covered with lichens and moss in early 1950s. Presently, there is still a trace of rock-cut stairs adjacent to Cave-1 on the left side climbing up to the hillock. The rock-cut chambers are empty and the images found here are housed in the Indian Museum at Kolkata by C S Banerjee. Apart from this there is a rock-cut image of Buddha (Padmapani) housed in the of wrecked rock cut cave in the southern slope near to the present exposed stupa site and presently under worship by the local as Ghantiasuni *thakurani*.

As far as Buddhism is concerned, Odisha is well known for its association with two important events when it was anciently known as Utkala & Kalinga. The first two disciples of Buddha (Tappasu & Bhallika) hailed from Utkala as narrated by Vinaya texts (*Mahavagga & Angattura Nikaya).* The famous Kalinga war of emperor Asoka fought at Dhauli in 261 B.C.E. not only transformed Chandasoka to Dharmasoka but also transformed Buddhism from a local religion of the Himalayan Tarai region to an international religion and the Buddha as the light of Asia. Later, the early Bhaumakara rulers were staunch followers of Buddhism and under the royal patronage of Bhaumakaras, the Buddhism became a state religion. The excavated remains and the archaeological evidences throw light on the flourishing state of Buddhism with several viharas including the ones at Lalitagiri, Udayagiri and Ratnagiri in the vicinity of Jajpur.

Objective of the excavation:

- The main objective of the excavation is to stop the mining operation by the Odisha Mining Corporation (OMC) a Government of Odisha mining PSU at Sukhuapadha (78.3 acres) in Jajpur district, and to preserve the archaeological vestiges scattered in the hillock.
- To know the nature of the structural remains at the top of the hill (137.48mt MSL).
- To preserve the rock cut caves in the northern slope as well as the rock cut Buddhist image Bodhisattva Padmapani (locally known as Ghantiasuni *thakurani* (goddess)) in the south part.
- To conserve, preserve and restore the heritage structures on the hillock.

Archaeological Excavation 2022-2023

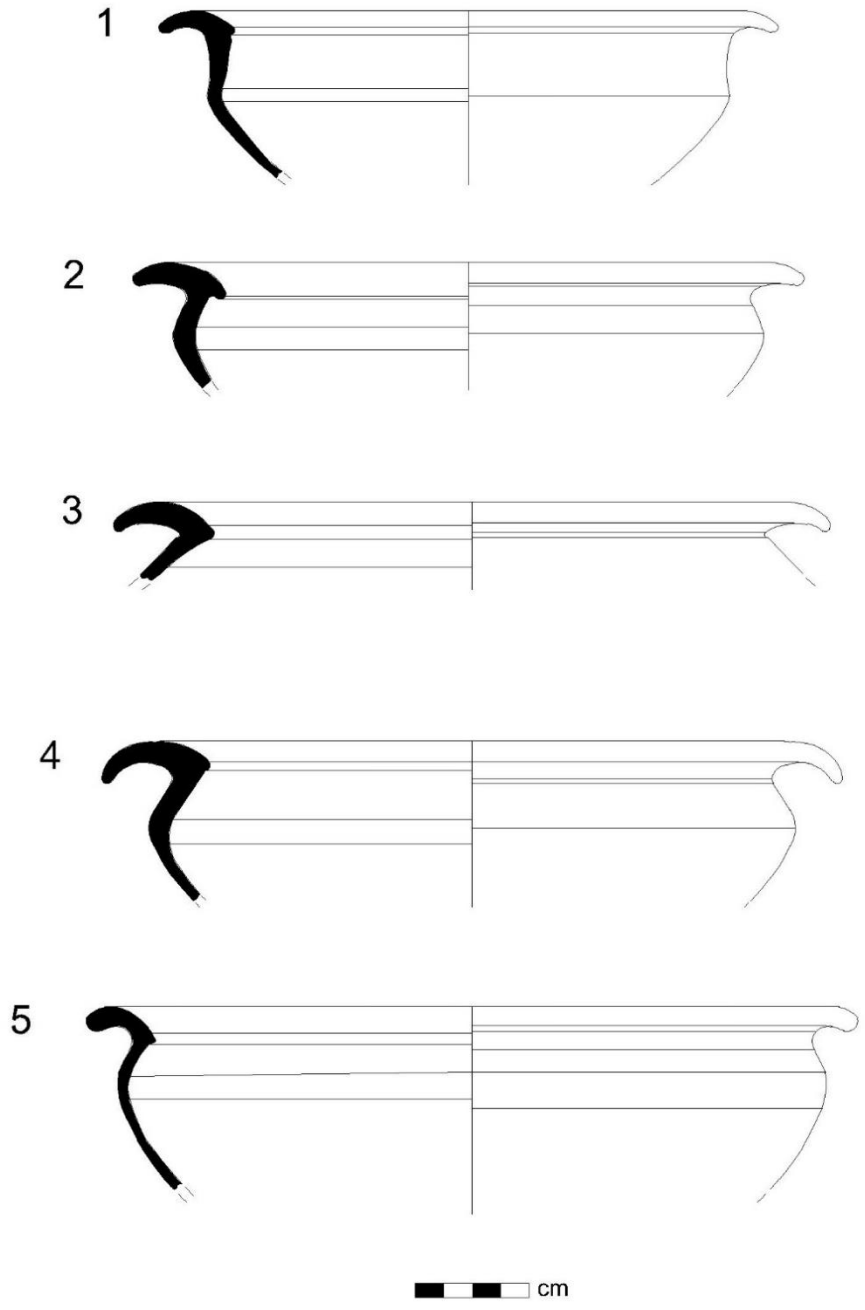
The excavation work revealed a stone build ashlar masonry stupa dated to 7th and 8th century CE. It is square on plan over a prepared surface of 10.80m square, resting directly over the natural rock surface at the top of the hillock known as Parabhadi (Lat. 20° 35′ 40″N Long. 86° 15′ 39″ E) Msl.137.487m. The square *medhi* measuring 8.60mt square having one projection at the centre measuring 2.30mt on all four sides. The height of the existing dilapidated stupa is 4.50m from the surface level. The stone masonry is anchored with iron clamp and fixed with rivetted pin head and the annular space are filled with specialized mud mortar mixed with stone chips and potsherds. During the spade work fourteen numbers artifacts made of stone and terracotta has been retrieved.

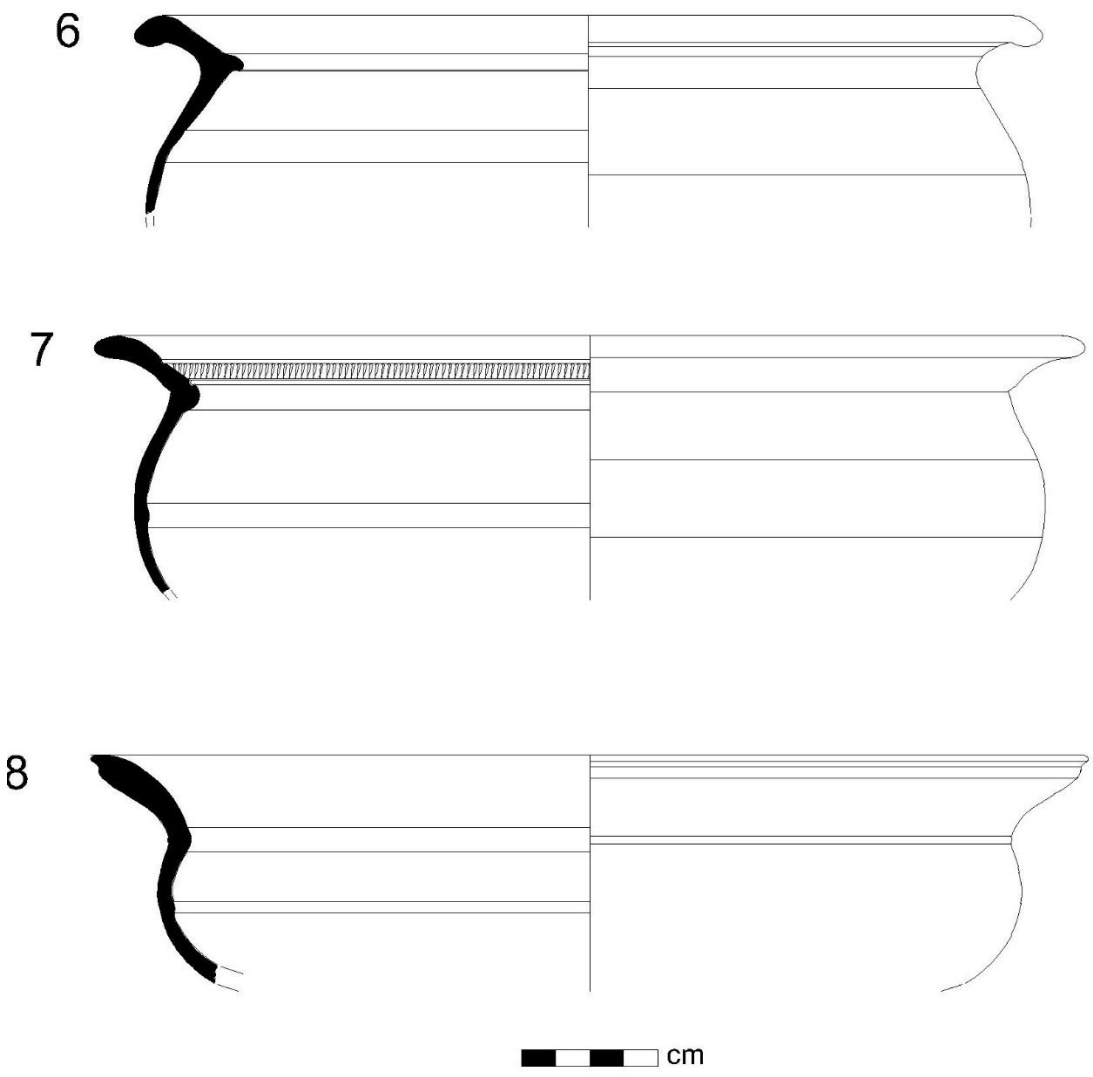
Pottery

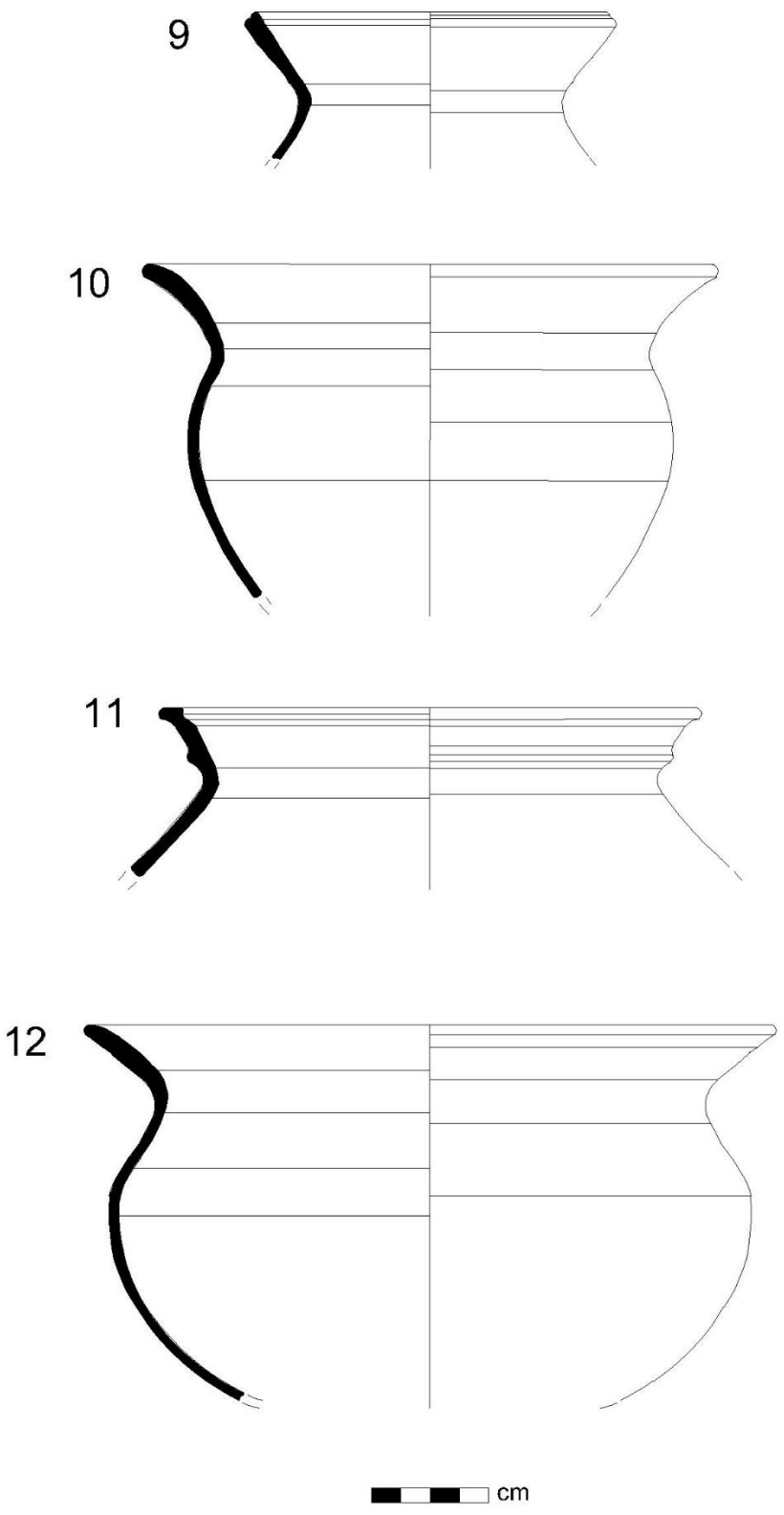
The ceramics retrieved in the site are dominated by red ware followed by grey ware of varying from light to dark in colour made of medium to coarse fabric having coarse sand as tempering material noticed in numbers of sherds. The shapes of the ceramics include handi, globular pot, necked jars, shallow and deep basins, and vase (Sl. No 1-20). Most of the ceramics are found with eroded outer surface with few indicating the presence of slip and wash.

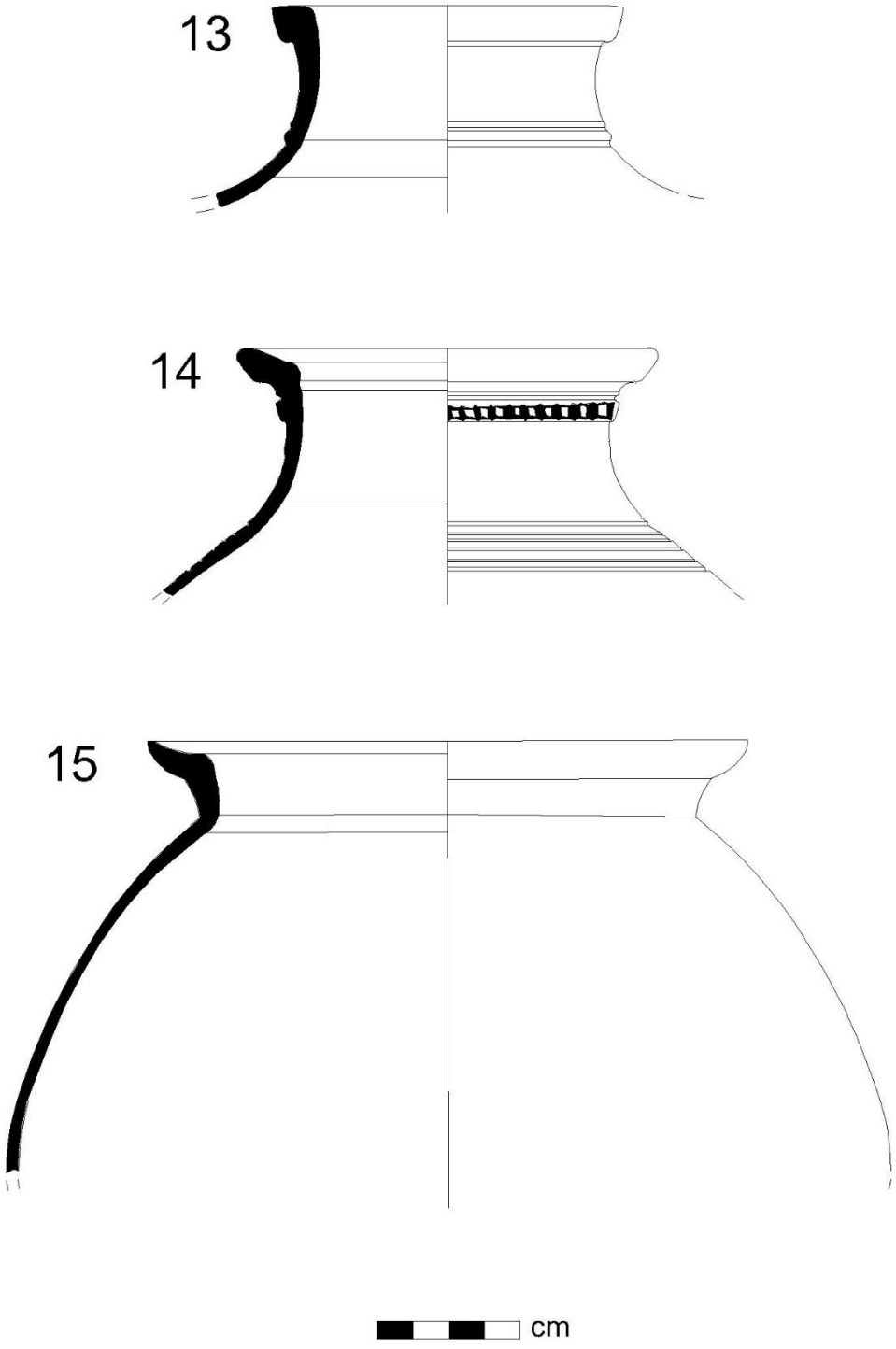
1. Fragment of a handi of grey ware with a beaked rim having carination at its neck.
2. Fragment of a handi of red ware with flared horizontal beaked rim having carination at its neck with a concave profile.
3. Fragment of a handi of grey ware with a beaked rim having carination at its neck.
4. Fragment of a handi of grey ware with horizontal splayed-out beaked rim having concave profile.
5. Fragment of a handi of dull grey ware with flared beaked rim having carination at its neck.
6. Fragment of a basin of grey ware with beaked rim having carination at its neck.
7. Fragment of a basin of dull red ware with flared thickened rim with internally carinated neck. It has incised design on its inner surface of rim between two grooved lines. It has a concave profile with a ridge on its inner side.
8. Fragment of a basin of grey ware with, out turned flared rim having a ridge running at its exterior neck. It has a concave profile with a ridge at its inner surface.

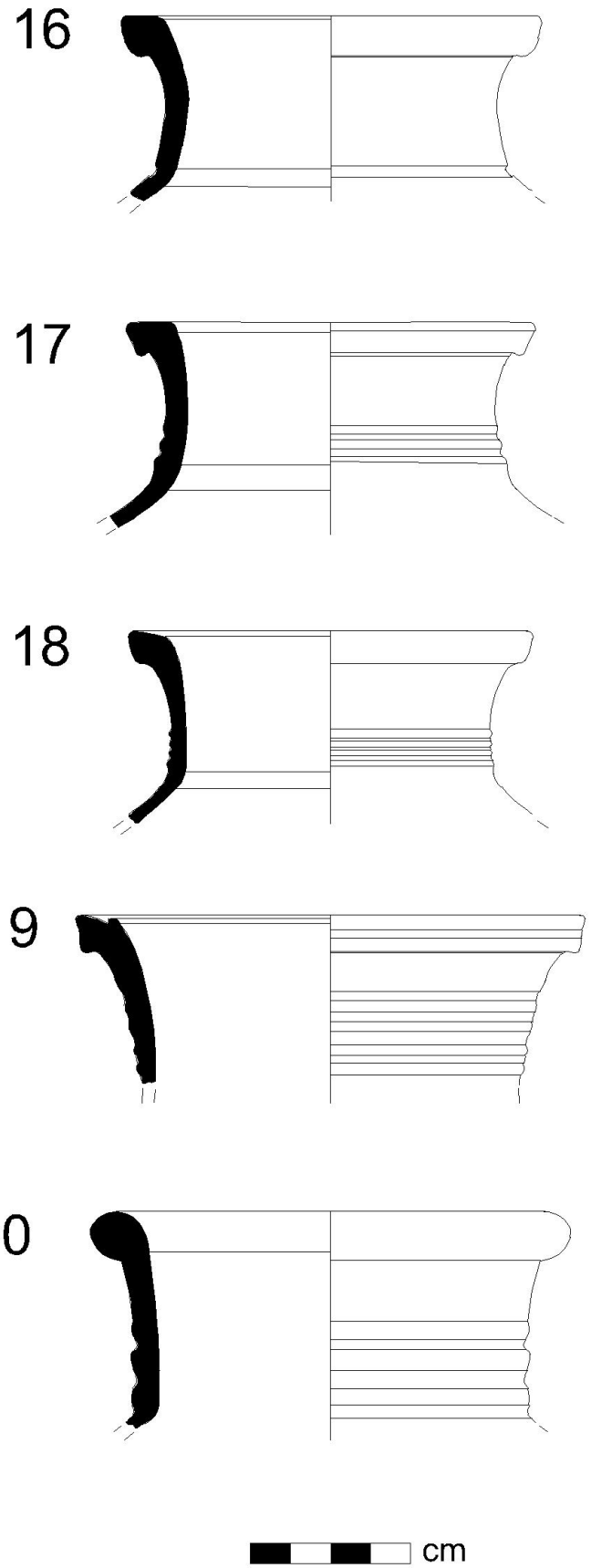
9. Fragment of a vase of grey ware having out turned splayed rim with a groove running around the edge of the rim.
10. Fragment of a vase of grey ware dull red ware having out turned flared rim with reduced grey core.
11. Fragment of a necked jar of grey ware having flared rim with a ridge at its neck and groove at its internal rim.
12. Fragment of a handi of grey ware having out turned flaring rim with concave profile and medium fabric.
13. Fragment of a necked jar of grey ware having thickened rim, medium fabric and decorated externally with a ridge at its neck.
14. Fragment of a globular pot of grey ware having out curved thickened rim with groove at its rim. A thick ridge running at its neck has series of incised designs. The shoulder portion has multiple incised lines.
15. Fragment of a globular pot of grey ware having out turned beaked rim having flat top surface with shallow depression.
16. Fragment of a necked vase of grey ware having out curved thickened rim with an incised groove at its neck at external surface.
17. Fragment of a necked vase of grey ware having out curved thickened rim having two incised grooves at its neck.
18. Fragment of a necked vase of grey ware having out curved thickened rim having multiple incised lines at its neck.
19. Fragment of a necked vase of grey ware having out curved thickened rim having multiple shallow grooves at its neck.
20. Fragment of a necked vase of grey ware having out curved thickened rim having multiple incised grooves at its neck.


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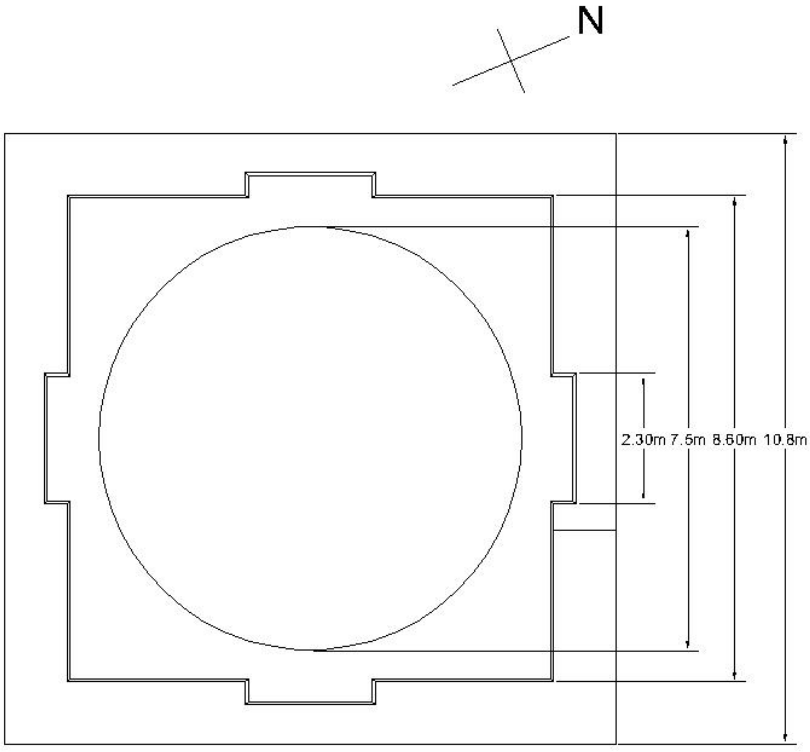

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Structure

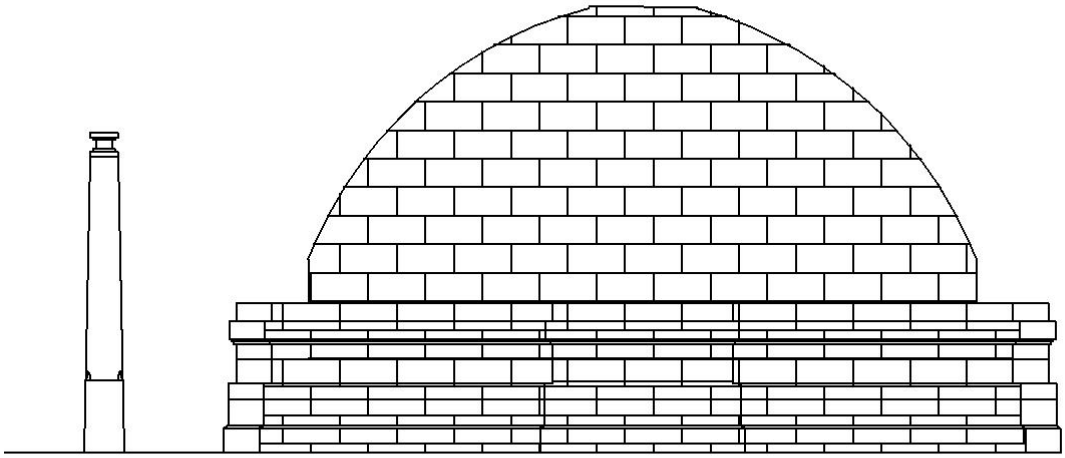
The structure is erected on the top of the hillock on an undulated natural rock boulder formation. To level the surface, few courses of stones were placed to make a common square platform measuring 10.8m x 10.8m, above which the stupa is erected. The stupa has a square base measuring 8.60m x 8.60m in plan and 4.50m in elevation constructed in ashlar masonry fashion.

The square base (*medhi*) of the stupa has a central projection about 2.3m x 0.45m on each side. The height of the basement measures 1.61m (average of all sides) having seven courses of stone masonry. Each course from bottom to top measuring 27cm, 28cm, 17cm, 24cm, 18cm, 25cm and 23cm respectively. Among these seven courses, course 1, 3 and 6 have specially carved edges.

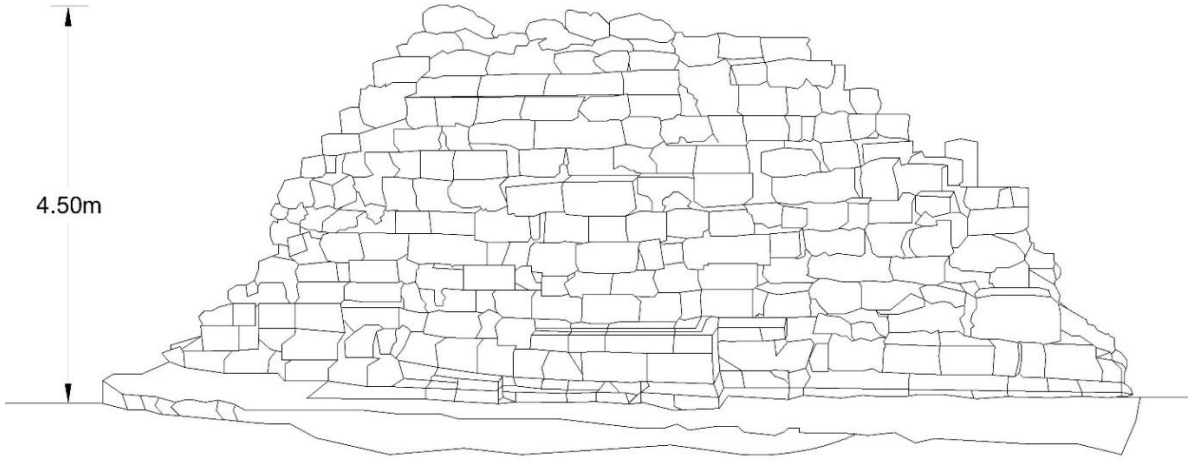
Above the basement, 10 to 11 courses of stones were placed in circular plan in receding fashion from bottom to top, which forms a semi-circular super structure (*anda*). The stone masonry is anchored with iron clamp and fixed with rivetted pin head. The annular spaces between the stones are filled with specialized mud mortar mixed with stone chips and potsherds. A broken fragment of carved stone pillar was found in the debris at south-east corner. This pillar fragment has a square base and circular shaft with four lotus buds on the corners.



Ground plan of Stupa



Conjectural drawing of Stupa



Elevation of Stupa facing south-east

Antiquities

A total number of 14 antiquities made out of stone and terracotta have been retrieved from the excavation.

S. No	Name of Antiquity	Material	Total Number
1	Disc	Stone	2
2	Sling Ball	Terracotta/Stone	2
3	Pestle	Stone	4
4	Sculpture	Stone	3
5	Fragment of Chhatravali	Stone	1
6	Terracotta Plaque	Terracotta	2






1 CM


1 CM


2 CM


2 CM

Sculptures

Fig. 1. Image of Dhyani-Buddha seated on *padmasana*, mounted on a *simhasana* with *padmabandana* moulding. The pedestal has two roaring lions on the sides. The head and hands are broken.

Fig. 2. Image of Buddha seated on *padmasana*, mounted on a *simhasana* having a *padmabandana* moulding. The pedestal has two lions on the sides. Left hand is shown in dhyana mudra broken from the elbow. The image is broken from the bust above.

Fig.3. A broken terracotta plaque arrayed with an image of Dhyani Buddha in *Dharmachakra-pravartana* mudra. Small votive stupas are flanked near the head, above the shoulder portion of the God.

Fig. 4. A small broken worn-out terracotta plaque which retains the head portion of Buddha.



Fig. 1 Dhyani-Buddha



Fig. 2. Dhyani-Buddha



Fig. 3. Terracotta plaque



Fig.4. Terracotta plaque



Pestle



Fragment of Chhatravali



Sculptural fragment of Vidhyadhara

Conclusion

The excavation work revealed a stone build ashlar masonry stupa dated to 7th-8th century CE affiliated to Mahayana Buddhism. It might be built under the patronage of Bhaumakara's and survived till 14th-15th century CE. The excavated stupa had a developed architecture form with unique features such as the carved basement of square plan with projections at all sides. The spade work as well as the pedestrian survey on the hillock also brought to light several vestiges of Buddhist affinities such as rock cut caves and chambers, sculptures and brick and stone structural remains. The glory of Odisha's Buddhism continued till 12th century CE and later on declined due to lack of royal patronage by later dynasties and come to an end with the death of last Hindu King Mukunda deva who killed by the iconoclast Suleiman Karrani (Kalapahara), the general of Bengal Sultan. The death of Mukunda deva in 1568 CE brought the solidarity of the state to an end. Thus, Odisha with its chequered career of Buddhism could not sustain after sixteenth century CE and the glorious chapter of history of Odisha's Buddhism came to an end.

Plates



Before excavation - Parabhadi (Sukhuapada)



General view of the stupa



During Excavation



3D-Laser Scanning Survey of the Stupa



Aerial Photography using Drone Camera



Aerial view of the Stupa



Aerial view of the Stupa



During Excavation



During Excavation



During Excavation



During Excavation



View of Stupa from South-east



View of Stupa from West



View of Stupa from East



Rock-cut Buddha Statue near the stupa



Trial-pit structural activity



Rock-cut caves locally known as *Hathikhal*



Mining activity near *Hathikhal*



General view of Stupa along with Mining activity by OMC



Mining activity by Odisha Mining Corporation



General view of Stupa along with disturbed structure by OMC

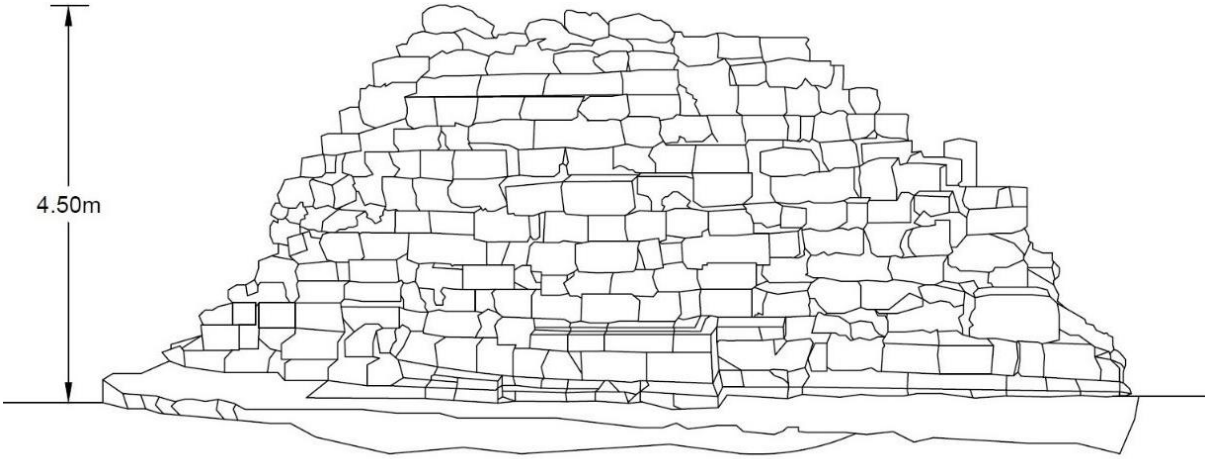


General view of Stupa along with Mining activity by local mining mafia

Acknowledgements

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Elevation of Stupa facing south-east

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